

Chapter 57-1

Jingyi Culture, seventh floor office.

A woman in a light gray suit leaned back, letting all her weight rest on the swivel chair. One hand rested on the armrest while the other held her phone face-down.

The green plants in the office had withered and yellowed, and the cactus on the desk looked gray and lifeless, completely devoid of vitality.

Two computers sat on the wooden desk, both powered on.

Messages kept popping up from below the computer screens.

One computer displayed Weibo, the other showed a green social media app.

The trending topics on Weibo were diverse, but several were particularly eye-catching:

《Afterglow》 Divine Cast#

#Zhao Ying 《Afterglow》 Stills#

#Yang Shuyan Special Appearance in 《Afterglow》 #

#Zhao Ying Yang Shuyan Possible Century Collaboration#

#Last-minute Replacement Young Lady Stars in 《Afterglow》 #

#Chen Liuying Loses 《Afterglow》 Role#

Although 《Afterglow》 was a typical yuri¹ urban drama, it had an excellent creative team, with the script written by renowned industry screenwriter Luo Pianran. It told the story of two girls' completely different lives.

The female lead was a fallen wealthy heiress, the second female lead was a perfectionist with obsessive cleanliness. Almost all the storylines centered on the female lead, while the third female role was the most important link in the female lead's story arc—a white lotus turned villain².

When Bai Weiwei first read the script, she immediately fell in love with this character. If Chen Liuying could play it well, it would be a turning point in her career.

Chen Liuying was also the strongest competitor for this role.

Although it was an open casting call for society, Chen Liuying's acting skills, popularity, and looks gave her absolute advantages among all competitors.

To secure this role, she even sent Chen Liuying to study with the best acting teacher at the Film Academy.

All this was just to have the most outstanding performance during that day's audition.

Chen Liuying's acting skills improved qualitatively in a short time.

Bai Weiwei had also indirectly inquired with the drama's producer, who said that for the third female role, the investors hadn't inserted anyone, and the director had no suitable candidate in mind. As long as Chen Liuying didn't make mistakes, she would definitely pass.

After all, she had traffic³.

Which drama would refuse to let a naturally trending actress play a supporting role?

So Bai Weiwei was very confident.

But she hadn't expected to encounter Liang Shi on audition day.

When Chen Liuying and Liang Shi competed for the same role, her heart still leaned toward Chen Liuying.

After all, for someone who had never acted before, she might shine in one performance due to her natural compatibility with the character.

But it was impossible to directly challenge such a demanding role right from the start.

You must know, this character's multiple reversals—even if Zhao Ying herself played it, she couldn't portray it thoroughly and penetratingly.

But after watching Liang Shi's audition that day, Bai Weiwei was shocked.

So talent could easily crush hard work.

She later inquired with 《Afterglow》's producer, who gave evasive responses. In the end, she couldn't secure this role.

Today was the day 《Afterglow》 released their character posters, and trending topics belonging to 《Afterglow》 dominated one after another.

Mixed among these trending topics was also Minghui Jewelry's autumn new collection launch.

Minghui Jewelry's autumn new products were eye-catching, receiving nothing but praise.

Bai Weiwei looked through all the trending topics again and again. After unlocking her phone screen, what appeared was the video she had recorded that day.

In the shopping mall's restroom, she had pushed Chen Liuying against the wall twice.

Footnotes: ¹ Yuri: A genre focusing on romantic relationships between women; in Chinese web novels, refers to GL (Girls' Love) stories ² White lotus turned villain: A character archetype that appears innocent and pure but reveals a dark, manipulative nature ³ Traffic: Industry term referring to an actor's ability to generate online buzz, views, and fan engagement

Chapter 57-2

Chen Liuying kept smiling throughout, while Xu Qingzhu frowned slightly with disgust in her eyes.

Their voices were very low, and combined with the sound of running water in the restroom and the overlapping footsteps outside, it was impossible to hear clearly what they were saying.

But the video alone was enough to prove certain things.

The media's specialty was nothing more than two things—creating something from nothing and making up stories from pictures.

And Bai Weiwei was well-versed in this.

Every celebrity's studio would cultivate a batch of marketing accounts¹—this was basically an unspoken industry rule.

Chen Liuying's studio was backed by Jingyi Culture. As Jingyi Culture's most promising artist, aside from the company's top actress Luo Fei, Chen Liuying received the best treatment.

The persona Bai Weiwei designed for Chen Liuying suited her perfectly, and in the early stages, it indeed attracted a group of devoted fans.

Even after the Huayue International incident was exposed and they missed the golden PR period, after Bai Weiwei was discharged from the hospital, she directly arranged for Chen Liuying to get injured, using fan abuse to solidify fan loyalty². After this series of moves, Chen Liuying's popularity not only didn't decrease but actually increased.

Currently, Chen Liuying was in her career's rising period. This video exposure would definitely have some impact on her professional career.

But Bai Weiwei was used to playing the fan abuse and loyalty solidification game. When the time came, she would post on Weibo indirectly saying Chen Liuying had been suffering from headaches for several days.

Once there was enough buzz and the media had thoroughly blackened Minghui Jewelry's reputation, Chen Liuying would then post on Weibo to explain.

She could explain everything ambiguously, saying it was because her inappropriate words had angered the Minghui heiress.

Based on netizens' psychology of hating the rich, Xu Qingzhu would definitely end up completely ruined along with her Minghui Jewelry.

Who told her to bully others with her power?

Who told her to hit people?

Could wealthy heiresses act recklessly?

Absolutely not.

Led by Chen Liuying's devoted fans, Minghui Jewelry would quickly fall.

For Chen Liuying, she could sell her misery and gain a large group of fans.

Chen Liuying's face was her most powerful weapon. As long as she trended, she would definitely gain followers.

Currently, several luxury brands had already made contact. After this incident, she should be able to secure half of them.

Brand sponsors never feared you having scandalous trending topics—they feared you having no trending topics at all.

Bai Weiwei was still internally conflicted and hesitant, after all, she had once been so close to Xu Qingzhu.

In university, they ate together, attended classes together, helped each other bring meals, and helped each other save seats.

Those happy campus times seemed vivid as yesterday, but now...

She clicked on the trending topics related to Minghui Jewelry. The associated terms were designer Cherry—Lin Luoxi, and Sally.

The top comments showed two photos.

Both were group photos of three people.

In the first photo, the people looked slightly younger but all smiled happily.

Xu Qingzhu stood in front, with Sally and Cherry behind her, both raising their arms to form hearts.

Behind them was a sky blue as wash water and emerald green mountains.

The second photo was much clearer, a recent picture.

In a coffee shop, the three people leisurely and comfortably drank coffee, their faces full of smiles.

The photo's caption read: [The Sheng family really didn't disappoint me! Outstanding graduates of Qingyi University³, university classmates with renowned domestic designer Lin Luoxi, parachuted into the company before the autumn new product launch, directly poached old classmates to support the scene. Nothing more to say, Minghui YYDS⁴!]

As a popular Weibo post, the comments were approaching ten thousand.

[Beautiful sisters gathering together is so pleasing to the eye.]

[This isn't really a socialite gathering, is it? It's the kind that makes your heart flutter just by looking.]

[I declare the second photo to be—socialites' afternoon tea.]

[Am I the only one who noticed that excellent people even have excellent friends?]

[The person above spoke the truth, I'm emo⁵ now.]

[...]

Friends...

Among her friends, she wasn't included.

Bai Weiwei's mouse clicked on the second photo. Sunlight streamed through the clean floor-to-ceiling windows, shining on them, looking leisurely and beautiful.

In contrast, the cactus on her desk.

It was a gift from Xu Qingzhu from the year before last.

Bai Weiwei closed her eyes and opened another computer's social media software, directly messaging a well-known industry marketing account: [Breaking news.]

The marketing accounts and active accounts the studio cultivated immediately came in handy.

Footnotes: ¹ Marketing accounts: Social media accounts specifically created to promote celebrities and manage their online image and reputation ² Fan abuse to solidify fan loyalty: A strategy where celebrities or their teams create situations that make fans feel protective, strengthening their emotional investment ³ Qingyi University: A prestigious fictional university ⁴ YYDS: Internet slang meaning "eternal god" or "forever the best" ⁵ Emo: Internet slang expressing feelings of sadness or emotional distress

Chapter 57-3

//

When the #Minghui Heiress Hits People# topic climbed to tenth place, it happened to be adjacent to the #Minghui Jewelry Autumn Collection So Beautiful# topic.

Inside Minghui Jewelry's office building.

"Now I can finally get a good night's sleep." Sally laughed in the office. "Blanche, you can put your heart at ease now."

"This is just the beginning." Although Xu Qingzhu was also happy, she remained rational. "We still have the twenty-four solar terms series¹ we planned, the traditional Chinese style series, and next year's spring collection. Isn't it too early to celebrate now?"

Sally felt her head getting big. "My goodness, Blanche, who are you trying to kill?"

Xu Qingzhu smiled. "I'll give you a vacation, okay?"

Sally was satisfied. "That's more like it."

"Taking a vacation, you'll just be like a wandering ghost." Lin Luoxi coldly interjected from the side. "What's the use of your vacation?"

"Wandering ghost?" Sally asked in her broken Chinese. "What does that mean?"

"It means doing nothing, wandering around aimlessly, being a waste who does nothing." Lin Luoxi gave her a high-difficulty explanation.

Sally was even more confused.

Xu Qingzhu didn't participate in their war. She was used to keeping a low profile at times like this.

On her computer was Minghui Jewelry's official website, with sales continuously growing.

The offline mall sales statistics were on another webpage, also viewable in real-time.

This product launch had received particularly good reviews. Including the Weibo trending topics, they had only bought one—the other two topics were organic traffic².

It could be considered a beautiful turnaround victory.

Xu Qingzhu's recent worries and fears finally eased somewhat. With the autumn collection's support, Minghui's path to recovery would be smoother.

The two people in the office were still constantly bickering with each other.

Her phone on the desk vibrated slightly. She opened it to see a message from Liang Shi, but before she could read the content clearly, Liang Shi's call came through.

Xu Qingzhu answered: "Teacher Liang, what's the matter?"

From her rising intonation, you could tell she was in a very pleasant mood.

Liang Shi paused for a moment, seeming to hesitate whether to say what she wanted to say. Once said, it would ruin her good mood.

But ultimately she chose to face reality: "Have you seen the trending topics?"

"What trending topics?" Xu Qingzhu's understanding of trending topics was still stuck at half an hour ago. She smiled. "Teacher Liang, do you mean the trending topic about your costume photos? I saw it."

"No." Liang Shi said. "Bai Weiwei and Chen Liuying bought you black trending topics³."

Xu Qingzhu's expression changed. "What do you mean?"

After asking, she felt the question was unnecessary and immediately said coldly: "Forget it, I'll see for myself."

From the moment she answered the phone, the office had quieted down.

So Liang Shi's words were accurately transmitted to Lin Luoxi and Sally's ears.

Footnotes: ¹ Twenty-four solar terms series: A traditional Chinese calendar system dividing the year into 24 periods based on seasonal changes, often used as design inspiration ² Organic traffic: Natural, unpaid trending topics that gain popularity through genuine user engagement rather than paid promotion ³ Black trending topics: Negative trending topics deliberately created to damage someone's reputation

Chapter 57-4

While Xu Qingzhu was refreshing the trending topics, Lin Luoxi asked in confusion: "What kind of trending topics could those two buy for you? About the restroom incident last time?"

Sally said: "But wasn't it obviously Bai Junior's fault that time?"

"Those who mix in the entertainment industry don't just have dirty hearts." Lin Luoxi had already seen the video and sneered. "Their methods are dirty too."

Sally: "?"

But no one came to answer Sally's question.

After Xu Qingzhu finished watching the video and those fabricated articles by marketing accounts, she only felt a chill down her spine.

She had never imagined that one day, she would encounter Bai Weiwei online in such a way.

She closed her eyes, wanting to send a message on her phone but found her hands were shaking. She took a deep breath, suppressing her bad emotions and trying to think about the problem as calmly as possible.

Just as she was about to search for the recording in her phone to send out, there was a knock on the office door.

It was the head of the PR department. "Vice President Xu, have you seen the trending topics?"

"I've seen them." Xu Qingzhu resumed her cool and indifferent demeanor. "I acted in self-defense and accidentally hurt someone. I didn't intentionally hit her, nor did I abuse my power, so this matter can be turned around."

"The sales department just contacted me, saying that because of this trending topic, our autumn collection's sales have obviously declined. There are also many of Chen Liuying's fans coming to return products and leave bad reviews. This matter must be handled as much as possible." The PR department head said: "But since it involves you, I still hope to get your opinion."

Before the words finished, a voice suddenly interrupted: "Sales decline? Which products?"

The PR department head was startled, but because of the oppressive tone in that voice, he instinctively answered: "All the products that went online today."

Sally was there watching the excitement unfold, saying gleefully: "Zhou Yi'an, your most proud work is included."

Zhou Yi'an had one hand in her pocket, a black denim jacket casually draped over her body—a very casual outfit that she wore with exceptional charm. Irritation flashed in her eyes, then her gaze passed over the PR department head to look at Xu Qingzhu. "Was it your bestie who did this?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She steadied herself, cleared her throat lightly, and said to the PR department head: "Let's go, meeting time."

She had the recording from that day, so she wasn't afraid.

Lin Luoxi and Zhou Yi'an both requested to attend the meeting.

Xu Qingzhu originally only wanted to meet with the PR department people, but seeing Lin Luoxi's expression, she guessed she might have some better ideas, so she agreed.

As for Zhou Yi'an.

Using her characteristically arrogant tone, she said: "My work's sales are affected, shouldn't I be involved?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Just as they entered the meeting room, Liang Shi's call came through again.

"Where are you now?" Liang Shi inquired.

"The company." Xu Qingzhu answered. "We're about to hold a related meeting for PR."

"The online public opinion has already fermented significantly, and the battle has even spread to Dongheng. Second Brother is with me now. We're coming to find you to align our stories." Liang Shi tactfully reminded: "After all, you now have another identity¹."

Xu Qingzhu understood her implication. "Got it."

She opened her computer and kept refreshing the trending topics.

The topic about her hitting someone had already reached first place, completely stealing the buzz from 《Afterglow》's official announcement.

What Liang Shi meant by "the battle spreading to Dongheng" was that someone had dug up her relationship with Liang Shi. They didn't drag Liang Shi into it, but they did reveal that she was the third young master's wife of Dongheng Group.

So online criticism now included Dongheng as well.

There were also many people fishing in troubled waters².

Saying that the third young lady of the Liang family was originally a wastrel³—arrogant, domineering, and imperious. Two people sleeping in the same bed wouldn't produce different personalities, so it was understandable that Xu Qingzhu would do such things.

And netizens felt even more pity for Chen Liuying.

She was already beaten but could still maintain her smile.

Truly, actors couldn't compete with capital.

Everyone seemed to have forgotten that after Chen Liuying's agent's suicide incident, they had furiously criticized them for kowtowing to capital.

But none of this mattered now.

Online opinions were boiling. In this battle of public opinion, Xu Qingzhu was at the center of the storm.

First they criticized her for being arrogant, then they dug up her identity as Dongheng's young mistress.

Subsequently, gossip emerged about her marrying into Dongheng to obtain financing, and claims about her chaotic private life during school, frequently leading on suitors and keeping a pond full of fish⁴.

In short, what everyone was originally arguing about no longer mattered.

They had gone too far down the path of eating melons⁵, having long forgotten why they started.

The office atmosphere was deathly still.

Meanwhile, Sally was quietly making big moves outside, posting on Weibo in her not-so-fluent Chinese: [Compared to her, Blanche is obviously more beautiful and more delicate. Why would you say Blanche hit someone? When our Blanche was in school, she couldn't bear to step on even an ant.]

Marketing accounts quickly reposted her Weibo and defined it as: Friend speaks out.

Netizens also rushed to her Weibo comments:

[Someone who couldn't bear to step on an ant dares to hit people?]

[They're all dogs raised by capital, what wouldn't they dare to do?]

[Being beautiful and delicate could also mean being a green tea bitch⁶! Just because she's pretty means she can hit people?]

[Can I slap you because I'm good-looking?]

[...]

Footnotes: ¹ Another identity: Referring to Xu Qingzhu's status as the wife of Liang Shi (third young master of Dongheng Group) ² Fishing in troubled waters: Taking advantage of chaotic situations for personal gain ³ Wastrel: A spoiled, irresponsible person from a wealthy family ⁴ Keeping a pond full of fish: Slang for leading on multiple romantic interests simultaneously ⁵ Eating melons: Chinese internet slang for consuming gossip and drama ⁶ Green tea bitch: Slang for someone who appears innocent and pure but is actually manipulative

Chapter 57-5

Sally's comment section immediately became a disaster. Lin Luoxi was the first to notice. She frowned and went to the office area to call Sally in, then confiscated her phone and deleted the Weibo post she had published.

In matters like this, the more you say, the more mistakes you make.

You must align your stories and deliver a fatal blow to the opponent directly.

The golden PR window is two hours. In this era of information explosion, netizens only have time to see you present definitive evidence.

Not this back-and-forth tearing at each other, which would only invite more criticism.

After being educated, Sally felt indignant and moved closer to Zhou Yi'an to look at her phone, only to discover that Zhou Yi'an wasn't looking at Weibo but was playing a match-three game.

Sally: "..."

She stirred up trouble out of boredom: "Please, your work's sales have dropped, you can't prove you're better than Cherry anymore. Aren't you worried at all?"

Zhou Yi'an glanced at her indifferently: "Shut up!"

Sally: "..."

Everyone was closely monitoring Weibo developments. As time passed, what was most affected was Minghui's autumn collection sales.

They were showing a trend of rapid decline.

But amid all the online criticism, suddenly a large number of accounts appeared, steering the narrative.

[Doesn't anyone really think their new products are absolutely beautiful?]

[Just that 'Light in the Autumn Night' piece alone, I'm absolutely in love with it! Already ordered. No one can oppose my beautiful jewelry.]

[And that 'Autumn Sound' piece, absolutely stunning! So beautiful it makes me nosebleed. Really, sisters, it's worth the investment!]

[If you're tight on money, I suggest getting the 'Falling Smoke' ring. It has the best value in the same price range.]

[...]

After more than ten minutes, following a significant drop, sales actually began to show an upward curve.

At the same time, Liang Shi and Liang Xinhe arrived with Dongheng's PR department head.

The first thing Liang Shi said upon seeing Xu Qingzhu was to ask quietly: "Are you okay?"

"Huh?" Xu Qingzhu was surprised: "I'm fine."

Liang Shi: "You're not heartbroken over Bai Weiwei's actions?"

Xu Qingzhu answered with unusual rationality: "Would being heartbroken be useful?"

Liang Shi: "..."

After they spoke quietly for a few sentences, they entered a business-like situation.

Both companies' PR departments had the same approach: issue lawyer's letters¹ at the fastest speed, then have Xu Qingzhu's account publish the recording, buy top-position trending topics, and take the opportunity to subtly imply that someone was spreading rumors.

Selling misery and pretending to be strong had always been conventional tactics.

After hearing this, Liang Xinhe looked at Xu Qingzhu and asked: "What's your opinion, Qingzhu?"

"Let's do it this way..." Before she could finish speaking, Liang Shi suddenly said: "Wait, don't do it yet."

Everyone's eyes fell on her. Dongheng's PR department head said: "If we miss the golden PR period, it will leave people with a fixed impression. Minghui Jewelry's reputation will decline, and sales are continuously dropping right now."

From his heart, he believed that Liang Shi, a layperson, understood nothing.

Did a wealthy heiress understand marketing? Did she understand PR?

She didn't! She just wanted to show her presence in such a big occasion. If it weren't for respect for General Manager Liang, his words would definitely be much harsher.

Even though he restrained himself, the contempt in his tone couldn't be hidden.

Hearing this made Liang Xinhe frown and sternly say: "Wu Sheng."

"General Manager Liang." Wu Sheng had already spoken, so naturally he had to maintain his position. "This is an obvious fact right now. I'm just telling the truth."

"But you can be more respectful." Liang Xinhe said: "If you feel the Liang family isn't worthy of you, you can seek other opportunities."

Saying this in front of another company was quite harsh.

Wu Sheng's expression immediately turned ugly.

Liang Shi originally hadn't taken his attitude to heart, but now that Liang Xinhe was standing up for her, she naturally couldn't plead for the other party—wouldn't that be slapping Liang Xinhe's face?

She just smiled: "Second Brother, let's discuss business first."

Liang Shi's laptop was placed in front of her, sitting in a side position, diagonally across from Zhou Yi'an.

Zhou Yi'an's match-three game on her phone was in a deadlock. She seemed to have lowered her eyes, but her peripheral vision kept glancing toward Liang Shi.

Liang Shi projected her computer screen: "I just borrowed some resources from Sister Ying and stirred up some online momentum, so now the new products' sales are recovering. They'll soon level off and return to the previous average sales peak. This is a wave of heavy traffic—why should we let it go?"

Everyone was stunned, feeling as if something was breaking through the soil in their hearts.

"You mean?" Xu Qingzhu's words paused, and a moment later, they said in unison: "Wait."

One was a questioning tone, the other gave a definitive answer.

"Call Bai Weiwei now." Liang Shi typed a string of words on the computer. "Ask her according to this. I'll record from the side."

Xu Qingzhu looked at the questions she typed out and frowned: "She's very cautious. She probably won't answer directly."

"It doesn't matter. You ask according to this, put it on speaker, and I'll help you with the follow-up questions." Liang Shi encouraged her.

She spoke with certainty, and Xu Qingzhu only hesitated for a moment before trusting her.

Xu Qingzhu dialed Bai Weiwei's number and asked according to Liang Shi's questions: "You recorded that video that day, right?"

Bai Weiwei frowned: "Who is this?"

"This is Xu Qingzhu." Xu Qingzhu said: "That day in the restroom, you recorded a video of me and Chen Liuying, didn't you?"

Bai Weiwei paused: "You're trying to fish for information?"

"I'm not. I just want to verify." Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together: "There's no surveillance in the restroom. I'm being wrongly accused now and can't do anything. The Minghui I just rescued has been destroyed by you like this. Destroying my life makes you happy, doesn't it? You clearly know that what happened that day wasn't my fault—it was Chen Liuying, it was your girlfriend bullying me. We've been friends for so many years..."

"You don't need to fish for my words!" Bai Weiwei said: "The trending topic incident wasn't my doing."

"But that day, besides the three of us, there was no one else." Xu Qingzhu looked at the script on screen and couldn't help but use a pitiful tone when speaking: "I'll accept today's events. I was careless in choosing friends, but you should at least let me die with understanding, right?"

"I don't understand what you're saying." Bai Weiwei still denied it.

Xu Qingzhu looked at the screen and said word by word: "Would you give up everything in this world for your girlfriend?"

Bai Weiwei's end paused. A few seconds later, she exhaled: "Xu Qingzhu, you forced me to this."

Xu Qingzhu was about to say more when Liang Shi took her phone and hung up directly.

Everyone looked at her, not understanding.

Liang Shi curved her lips in a light smile: "The fish is about to take the bait."

Footnotes: ¹ Lawyer's letters: Legal documents sent as warnings before potential litigation, commonly used in Chinese business disputes